

Selects: A Client Gallery & Proofing Platform

Role: Founder, Product Designer | **Timeline:** 2026 - Present | **Stack:** Lovable, Supabase, Resend

Explore the platform: <https://selects-gallery-foundation.lovable.app/>

View my work: @ethaninfocus on Instagram, portfolio view coming soon!

What is Selects?

Selects is a client gallery and proofing platform I designed and built for my own freelance photography business. Clients receive a private link, review their shoot across three browsing modes, and finalize their selections, with pricing updating live as they go. On my side, a single dashboard handles every shoot from upload through delivery.

I built it because the tools available for this workflow were either bloated SaaS platforms priced for full-time studios, or manual processes stitched together from Google Drive links and email threads. None of the options fit my specific workflow, so I decided to build one custom by myself!

The Problem to Solve

The post-production and business management aspect of freelance photography is one of the most commonly cited pain-points of client work. It was what deterred me from taking on clients for the first three years of my photography journey.

Before Selects, delivering a shoot to a client required a folder of watermarked previews sent over email, a separate thread to collect their picks, and a manual invoice based on how many photos they chose. Every step added friction, for the client and for me, which bottlenecked the number of bookings I could take. Clients had no good way to compare photos side by side or browse on their phone without downloading a bloated app. I had no way to see, at a glance, which shoots were waiting on a client decision versus ready for final delivery.

On top of the clunky workstreams, the deeper problem was pricing. My packages are priced by photo count, with a pay-per-photo rate covering anything beyond the included number. That meant the final price depended entirely on what a client selected, and without live tracking, both of us were stuck manually recounting photos against the contract rate before I could send an invoice.

I wanted the process to be easier and more transparent, for both client and photographer.

Process & Key Decisions

Three browsing modes, one selection state. Clients review photos differently depending on context: a quick pass on their phone, a careful side-by-side comparison, a deliberate scroll through everything. I built three interfaces, grid view with checkmarks, a Tinder-inspired swipe-based deck, and a full-screen lightbox, all reading from and writing to the same live selection state. Having three options meant more versions to polish and get right, but it was worth it. A single browsing mode would have forced every client into an experience that may not have matched how they actually wanted to review their photos.

Watermarking at upload, not on demand. Every photo gets a watermarked preview and thumbnail generated client-side the moment it's uploaded, rather than watermarked dynamically when a client views it. This makes gallery load times fast and keeps the full-resolution original stored and untouched until release. The tradeoff: if I change the watermark style or opacity, it doesn't apply retroactively to already-uploaded photos. I came across this issue when I found a bug where opacity wasn't actually being controlled the way I intended, and the fix was only applied to newly uploaded photos and, not to

the backlog of already-uploaded images. That was an acceptable gap while I was testing the platform on myself, but it's not practical once real clients are relying on it, so re-rendering watermarks live for existing photos is one of the first changes I'm making before opening Selects up beyond my own use.

Live variable pricing tied to selection. Each shoot has its own package price, included photo count, and marginal per-photo rate. As a client selects photos, the price updates in real time based on that shoot's specific tiers. This eliminated the manual recounting step entirely and meant that by the time a client finalizes, I already know exactly what to invoice.

A manual release toggle, set to off by default. A client submitting their picks doesn't automatically make it downloadable. I control exactly when a client can access their finished, unwatermarked photos through a single toggle on my dashboard. This gave me a clean checkpoint between "client has picked their favorites" and "client has paid and received final files," which matters for a business where payment and delivery aren't always simultaneous.

Dual access paths and the security tradeoff that came with it. Clients can reach their gallery through a private unique link or through a public name-and-PIN lookup, for cases where a client loses their original link. Adding the second path introduced a security consideration of brute-force password attacks, so I built in rate limiting of password attempts, a generic error message that never reveals which field was wrong, and temporary lockouts after repeated failures. The convenience of a recoverable access path was worth the added complexity, but only if it was secure.

Device-aware downloads. iOS Safari can't auto-extract a ZIP file into Photos, so mobile clients get a native share-sheet flow instead, while desktop clients get a single "Download All" ZIP. Handling this by device rather than shipping one universal (and worse) experience meant more branching logic, but it meant every client is able to receive photos onto their device without extra steps.

The Result

Selects now runs my client workflow end to end, from upload through final delivery. I've run it past 5 clients and 3 photographers through real bookings and live walkthroughs, and used their feedback to prioritize and ship changes to the selection flow and gallery navigation, catching friction points I couldn't see from the inside.

On the Horizon

The next iteration of Selects closes a few gaps that only surfaced through my own testing. Watermarks currently only update for photos uploaded after a change, so I'm rebuilding that to re-render live across existing photos, since that's not practical once real clients depend on the gallery being current. I'm also adding the ability for clients to set a custom PIN instead of relying on an auto-generated one, and giving myself the ability to edit client information directly from the dashboard, for cases where a client's name gets mistyped at intake and needs a quick fix rather than a database workaround.

Beyond that, I want to extend Selects from a post-shoot proofing tool into a full client management dashboard that covers the relationship before the shoot happens, not just after. The first piece is a shoot planning and collaboration page: a shared space where a client and I can align on direction ahead of time through mood boards, either linking out to Pinterest for clients who want to build their own board, or choosing from a small set of pre-built options for clients who'd rather not start from scratch. Right now that alignment happens over text and scattered links, which is the same fragmented pattern Selects was originally built to fix on the delivery side.

Payment processing and contracts remain deliberately out of scope for now, kept out to keep the core workflow tight while I validate the planning and delivery pieces first.